

MAY 10, 2026

# The Operating Brief

For Australian business operators

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TODAY'S BRIEFING

## | AI & TECHNOLOGY

Nvidia has committed \$40 billion to equity deals in AI companies in 2026 alone — a figure that reframes the chipmaker not just as a hardware supplier but as an active force shaping which AI companies win. The bet is enormous and deliberate: whoever controls compute and capital controls the next era of tech. Meanwhile, the Musk vs. Altman legal war escalated again, with OpenAI firing back at Elon Musk's lawsuit and insider Shivon Zilis revealing Musk once tried to recruit Sam Altman himself.

Oracle handed laid-off employees a blunt lesson: when workers tried to negotiate better severance after job cuts, the company simply refused. In a tight AI talent market, big tech's loyalty runs only as far as it's legally required to. On the consumer front, AI-powered kids' toys are proliferating with almost no regulatory oversight — Ars Technica's investigation reveals a Wild West of devices collecting children's data, raising urgent questions for parents and policymakers alike.

## | AUSTRALIAN BUSINESS & FINANCE

One Nation scored its best federal result in years, winning seats that could give Pauline Hanson's party influence over the balance of power in the Senate. For business operators, this matters: One Nation's positions on immigration policy, energy transition, and foreign investment diverge sharply from the major parties. That kind of senate

leverage can stall legislation, complicate approvals, and shift the political calculus for industries from mining to manufacturing.

Queensland is quietly sitting on a costly problem: aging underground pipes beneath streets and homes are at risk of failure, with councils warning replacement costs could stretch into the billions. It's the kind of infrastructure deficit that rarely makes headlines until something breaks — and then it makes all of them. Western Australian teenagers, meanwhile, are already using anonymous "alt" accounts to sidestep the state's social media ban, a reminder that digital regulation moves slower than the users it targets.

## **| WORLD MARKETS & GLOBAL BUSINESS**

A coordinated international cyberattack hit universities and schools across multiple countries, knocking out systems and exposing how porous institutional networks remain. For any organisation that hasn't hardened its defences, this is a timely warning. Putin appeared at a deliberately scaled-back Victory Day parade, using the occasion to denounce NATO rather than display strength, signalling that Russia's geopolitical posture is hardening even as its military resources are stretched.

Israeli strikes in Lebanon killed 39 people while Iran accused the US of a "reckless military adventure," ratcheting up tension across the Middle East. Oil markets remain acutely sensitive to any escalation in the region. Australian exporters and importers watching shipping routes and energy costs should keep a close eye on how this develops.

## **| THE BIG PICTURE**

Nvidia's \$40 billion AI investment spree is the clearest signal yet that the race isn't just about building better models — it's about owning the companies that will dominate every sector of the economy. This is no longer a tech story; it's an industrial strategy. The companies placing these bets now are writing the rules that everyone else will play by in five years.

For Australian business leaders, the operational question is no longer "should we adopt AI?" but "how fast and how deep?" The podcast this week from Atlassian co-founder Mike Cannon-Brookes on building AI-native teams is a practical place to start. The Oracle layoffs and the global investment wave point in the same direction: the transition is accelerating, and standing still is its own kind of risk.

Full stories and links are below.

#### WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

Nvidia just committed \$40 billion to AI investments this year alone — and that pace won't slow. If your workplace still hasn't introduced AI tools, now's the time to ask rather than wait.

Workers who learn to use AI become more valuable; those who don't risk being replaced by those who do.

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#### AI STORIES

##### | OVERVIEW

Nvidia has committed \$40 billion to equity AI investments in 2026 alone, cementing its role as both hardware leader and strategic kingmaker across the AI industry. The Musk vs. Altman legal battle intensified as OpenAI responded to Elon Musk's lawsuit, with Shimon Zilis revealing Musk once attempted to recruit Sam Altman to his own venture. Oracle's flat refusal to negotiate severance with laid-off workers signals that big tech is taking a harder line on AI-driven workforce restructuring.

TECHCRUNCH · INDUSTRY NEWS

## **Nvidia has already committed \$40B to equity AI deals this year**

Nvidia has deployed \$40 billion into equity stakes in AI companies in 2026 alone, moving far beyond its role as a chip supplier. The scale of investment signals Nvidia is positioning itself as a structural owner of the AI economy, not just a picks-and-shovels play.

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MIT TECHNOLOGY REVIEW · LAB ANNOUNCEMENT

## **Musk v. Altman week 2: OpenAI fires back, and Shivon Zilis reveals that Musk tried to poach Sam Altman**

OpenAI responded aggressively to Elon Musk's ongoing lawsuit, and Shivon Zilis dropped a bombshell: Musk once tried to recruit Sam Altman away from OpenAI for his own AI venture. The saga is no longer just a legal dispute — it's a fight over the governance and future direction of the most powerful AI lab in the world.

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TECHCRUNCH · INDUSTRY NEWS

## **Laid-off Oracle workers tried to negotiate better severance. Oracle said no.**

Oracle flatly refused to negotiate improved severance packages with workers it laid off, despite organised employee efforts to secure better terms. The move reflects a broader hardening of big tech's position on workforce restructuring as AI-driven efficiency cuts accelerate.

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ARS TECHNICA · INDUSTRY NEWS

## **The new Wild West of AI kids' toys**

AI-powered toys for children are proliferating rapidly with almost no regulatory framework governing what data they collect or how they behave. The investigation raises serious concerns for parents and highlights a regulatory gap that governments — including Australia's — have yet to close.

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HUGGING FACE · RESEARCH

## **OncoAgent: A Dual-Tier Multi-Agent Framework for Privacy-Preserving Oncology Clinical Decision Support**

Researchers have developed OncoAgent, a multi-agent AI framework designed to support oncology clinical decisions while preserving patient privacy. The system demonstrates how agentic AI architectures can be applied to high-stakes medical environments where data sensitivity is paramount.

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PODCAST PICKS

THE AI DAILY BRIEF: ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE NEWS AND ANALYSIS

## **How to Build an AI Native Team with Mike Cannon-Brookes**

Atlassian co-founder Mike Cannon-Brookes shares his framework for building teams that have AI embedded into their workflows from the ground up. A practical episode for Australian business leaders wrestling with how to operationalise AI adoption rather than just talk about it.

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THE COGNITIVE REVOLUTION | AI BUILDERS, RESEARCHERS, AND LIVE PLAYER ANALYSIS

## **Milliseconds to Match: Criteo's AdTech AI & the Future of Commerce**

Criteo's AI leaders explain how real-time machine learning models make advertising matching decisions in milliseconds, and what this means for the future of digital commerce. A deep look at how AI is reshaping the economics of online retail at infrastructure level.

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WORLD NEWS

## **| GLOBAL SNAPSHOT**

A coordinated international cyberattack disrupted universities and schools across multiple countries, exposing critical vulnerabilities in institutional digital infrastructure. Russian President Putin used a scaled-back Victory Day parade to denounce NATO, signalling no near-

term shift in Russia's hardened geopolitical posture. Israeli strikes killed 39 people in Lebanon while Iran accused the US of a "reckless military adventure," intensifying Middle East tensions with direct implications for global energy markets.

BBC NEWS

## **International cyber attack disrupts swathe of universities and schools**

A coordinated cyberattack struck education institutions across multiple countries, taking down systems and disrupting operations at scale. The incident is a stark reminder that under-resourced institutions remain prime targets — and that any organisation sharing infrastructure or vendor relationships with the sector faces residual risk.

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BBC NEWS

## **Putin denounces Nato at scaled-back Victory Day parade**

Russia's Victory Day parade was deliberately smaller than in previous years, with Putin using the occasion to attack NATO rather than showcase military strength. The optics reinforce a prolonged geopolitical standoff with no clear off-ramp, keeping European instability and its downstream economic effects firmly in play.

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BBC NEWS

## **Lebanon says Israeli strikes killed 39**

Israeli strikes on Lebanon killed 39 people, escalating the conflict at the same time Iran accused the US of conducting a "reckless military adventure" in the region. The dual flashpoints are keeping Middle East risk elevated, with oil prices and global shipping routes sensitive to any further deterioration.

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AUSTRALIAN NEWS

## **| AUSTRALIA SNAPSHOT**

One Nation scored a historic federal parliamentary result, positioning Pauline Hanson's party as a potential balance-of-power force in the Senate with real policy influence. Western Australian teenagers are already bypassing the state's social media ban via anonymous alt

accounts, exposing the limits of digital regulation and prompting fresh scrutiny of enforcement. Queensland authorities have warned that aging underground pipes across the state represent a multi-billion-dollar infrastructure liability that is largely invisible until it fails.

BBC NEWS

## **Australia's right-wing One Nation party scores historic parliamentary win**

One Nation achieved its strongest federal electoral result, winning seats that could give the party significant leverage in a closely divided Senate. For Australian businesses, One Nation's policy positions on immigration, energy, and foreign investment could complicate or delay reform in several key sectors.

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ABC NEWS

## **WA teens say anonymous 'alt' accounts used to bypass social media ban**

Teenagers in Western Australia are already circumventing the state's social media age restrictions by creating anonymous alternative accounts, undermining the intent of the legislation. The workaround highlights a persistent gap between digital policy design and on-the-ground user behaviour that regulators and platform operators have yet to bridge.

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ABC NEWS

## **The invisible problem sitting under Queensland streets and homes**

Aging underground pipe infrastructure across Queensland has been flagged as a serious and largely hidden liability, with authorities warning of potential catastrophic failures and replacement costs running into the billions. The issue compounds existing pressures on state budgets and raises long-term questions for property owners and developers across affected regions.

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THE NUMBER

# \$40 billion

Nvidia has committed \$40 billion to equity stakes in AI companies in 2026 alone — a signal that the AI buildout is accelerating faster than most Australian businesses have planned for.

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